REPUBLIC OF NAMIBIA

MINISTRY OF AGRICULTURE, WATER & LAND REFORM

Ministerial Statement on the repatriation of the Batswana of Namibian Descent.

BY

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- **Hon. Prof Peter Katjavivi, Speaker of the National Assembly.**
- **Distinguished Hon. Members,**

Today I have a special honor to stand in this August House, to inform you and the entire Namibian nation on a very important historical event- the relocation of Batswana of Namibian descent. Cabinet directed that the relocation process of the Batswana of Namibian Descent must be carried out collectively by the Ministries of Agriculture, Water and Land Reform (as a Lead Ministry), Ministry of Home Affairs, Immigration, Safety and Security and the Ministry of International Relations and Cooperation.

Honorable Members,
As may you be ware for almost the past 10 years, Namibian has been seized with discussion regarding repatriation of Batswana of Namibian descent to Namibia. These communities have made a calculated decision to come to their ancestral land after their ancestors were forced to flee this country due to colonial subjugation.

The decision of these communities to return to their motherland must be seen as a process of restorative justice. Their envisaged decision for repatriation must remind us that we have a long to achieve total restorative justice as there are still other forms injustices still exist in our midst after Namibian attained its independence.

The 1904-1907 atrocities committed by the imperial Germany, can be viewed in a coin head and tail scenario- In the minds of the colonizers, they view that as victory, but in the Namibian context it reminds us the bravely and resilience of the Namibian because that community through hardship was able cross the Botswana border hopefully so many days without food and water. That was extra bravely and resiliency I spoke about. We shall forever not forget the atrocities committed which associated with this brutal history!

Honorable Speaker

Honorable Members

The time for this long awaited relocation has arrived. The two governments, Namibia and Botswana have agreed on the relocation date to be the 20 September 2024. Hence the Ministry of Agriculture, Water and Land Reform supported by the Inter-Ministerial Committee made of representatives from , Ministry of International Relations and Cooperation (MIRCO), Ministry of Home Affairs, Immigration, Safety and Security, Ministry of Finance and Public Enterprise, Ministry of Urban and Rural Development (MURD), Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture, Ministry of Works and Transport and Ministry of Health and is in a full gear for the preparations of the envisaged relocation.

To smoothen the process,the repatriation of the Batswana of Namibian Descent will be done into two phases. Phase one comprised the less complicated group. The group without livestock

and Phase will comprise of a more logistic complicated group which will come with livestock.

In context, so far about One Hundred (100) Batswana of Namibian descent have been registered for the repatriation. But only 98 people distributed across 49 householders/families will definitely arrive on the said date. The registered people have already renounced their Motswana citizenship.

The renunciation process is currently which might increase the number to go up since the registration process is still on-going. However such people who are currently registering will only be able to come to Namibia in the second phase of the process.

The first group will be repatriated on the 20TH September 2024. This group is coming from the red zone area, from places like Ngamiland and Okavango area. This group is coming without livestock.

The second group, will be coming from the Green zone such as Ghanzi area etc, and this group will be repatriated with their livestock. Their repatriation will be done at a later stage on a date yet to be agreed by the two governments..

- **Honourable Speaker,**
- **Honourable Members**

In preparation to receive the long anticipated Batswana of Namibian Descent, the Ministry of Agriculture, Water and Land Reform has secured a site of Twenty One Hectares (21 hectares) which will serve as a reception area. The site is situated in Gam. In addition to the reception area, the Ministry of Agriculture, Water and Land Reform in collaboration with the Kambazembi Traditional Authority has secured a communal area in West of Gam known as Otjipaheua, with a size of (Two Hundred and Forty Five Thousand, Eight Hundred and Seven Hectares) (245807 hectares) designated as a grazing area for the livestock of the Batswana of Namibian Descent. My Ministry has thus far drilled boreholes in the area, installed water tanks, solar lights and constructed animal handling facilities. To this we would like to once again extend our sincerely appreciation to the Kambazembi Traditional Authority for avail the above said communal land.

In addition, the Ministry of Agriculture, Water and Land Reform acquired five (5) commercial farms in Omaheke, Otjozondjupa and Hardap regions with a combined size of Twenty Three Thousand and Fifty Four, Hectares (**23,054 hectares),** at a cost of **N$ 58,774,654.63** for the resettlement of the Batswana of Namibian Descent.

The Ministry has also acquired food items and sleeping tents for the Batswana of the Namibian Descent.

- **Honourable Members**

The two Governments have also agreed to hold a reception ceremony to be conducted on the Namibian side on 20TH September 2024. At the said reception ceremony, it is expected from the Government of the Republic of Botswana to officially handover the Batswana of Namibian Descent to the Government of the Republic of Namibia. The two Governments have also develop a joint Program for the reception ceremony.

The Government of the Republic of Namibia has designated Honourable Dr. Albert Kawana, Minister of Home Affairs, Immigration, Safety and Security to officially receive the Batswana of Namibian Descent on the 20TH September 2024. The designated entry border is Dobe border post. There will be an official ceremony at the Dobe Boarder Post. The Government of the Republic of Namibia has put all the mechanisms in place to ensure that the Batswana of the Namibian Descent are integrated into the mainstream of the country.

The Government of the Republic on Namibia will ensure that the Batswana of Namibian Descent to be repatriated will be issued with Identity Documentation, and that the school going children will be enrolled into Government schools to enable them to complete their

school terms. Furthermore, the Ministry of Health and Social Services will also be on the site to register the Batswana of Namibian Descent and assist them with medical services. Other Ministry such as Ministry of Informational and Communication will act a canter of information with regards to information dissemination. Cabinet has directed that exemption be granted to the Batswana of Namibian Descent on the following:

- Value Added Tax (VAT) on personal (movable assets) and household goods to be imported by Batswana of Namibian Descent.
- Environmental Levies for twenty five (25) motor vehicles owned by the Batswana of Namibian Descent.

The Ministry of Agriculture, Water and Land Reform has already made an application to NAMRA, for the above said exemption, and NAMRA is considering the application.

At this juncture, I would like to invite all Honourable members of this August house to grace the occasion of the repatriation of the Batswana of Namibian Descent on the 20TH September 2024, at Dobe Boarder post.

I thanks you for your attention.